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Marty Napoleon

Pianist Marty Napoleon was born in New York on June 2, 1921. He was working steadily in jazz by his early twenties, performing with Chico Marx, Joe Venuti and Charlie Barnet. Marty had the opportunity to work with his uncle Phil in the Memphis Five and with his brother Teddy in a piano quartet. He toured and recorded with Louis Armstrong, Gene Krupa, Red Allen and led his own piano trio. A lifelong resident of New York, he continues to perform and share his wealth of jazz lore.

Marty was interviewed in New York City on January 15, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan, and I'm very pleased to have Marty Napoleon with me today, who is a jazz pianist with a long and successful career, and I just learned quite a collector and annotator of your own career too. So welcome.

MN: Thank you, Monk. It's a pleasure to meet you.

MR: You seem to have a lot of enjoyment in your career in that you've saved all this material, and you're very proud of your travels.

MN: Oh yes. Well a funny thing is about my traveling and about my performances as a piano player, people have often asked me after a concert, they would come up to me, or during concerts on the break or something and say, "Are you really having that much fun, or are you just doing that for cameras and stuff?" I say, "well let me ask you a question. What would you like to do more than anything else in the world? What's your favorite hobby?" And somebody would say baseball or football, golf. So say they say, "I like to golf." I say, "okay, all right, you like to golf? Do you love it with all your heart?" "Yeah, I guess so." "Well suppose you went out golfing every day of your life, and you got paid for it." It's like the baseball players, right? These guys, they love to play baseball, they go out and they get paid. Golfers love to golf and they get paid for it. I play the piano. And I'm so lucky to have people pay me for what I'm playing. I mean come on. Why shouldn't I be happy up there, I love it, it's great, I'm having a ball.

MR: Can you recall at what age did you think you could actually make a career as a musician?

MN: I recall every day of my life just about, I swear, all of it. Really. I remember asking my mother a question once, where I said, "Mom, you remember when you were scrubbing the floor in the kitchen?" And she uttered some obscenity about some neighbors or somebody, and I said, "were you talking about me?" She said, "no, honey, not you, no, no, I mean them." So I said, "how old was I then?" She says, "you were two years old." And after that she says, "I thought you were going to be a school teacher because I used to stand up and by the time I was three or four years old I used to stand on the chair by the kitchen table, and bang the table, and speak gibberish. She thought I was making speeches, which I was, I was making speeches and banging my fist on the table. So I remember all of these crazy little things you know. But as far as being a musician or a piano player, well the fact is that when I was about seven or eight years old I had a brother who was like four or five years older than I, and he was kind of like a Danny Kaye kind of character, he was crazy, he was like a nut job. He'd do all these crazy motions. And he used to sing like comedy songs. And I used to sing harmony to him. And my father, who was a banjo player, said, "this kid's got a great ear." And I had a good ear, because I could hear harmonies at the time I was about seven years old. And when I used to go to grammar school, we'd sit in the auditorium and they'd say "everybody stand up, we're going to sing the 'Star Spangled Banner'" and the kids would be singing [sings] Oh say can you see—and I was singing [sings harmony] Oh say can you see, by the dawn's early light. And the kid next to me says, "hey, you're singing it wrong." I says, "shut up, I know what I'm doing." I was singing counterharmonies. I mean this is what I heard. And the funny thing is, to jump ahead of myself, when I was with the Chico Marx band, one of my first big bands, actually there was band before that was my first big band, but Chico Marx was my first name big band. And we played, you know Chico Marx, the Marx Brothers, and I was on the road with that band for a year and a half. My wife, we had just gotten married and we were on the road, and we were doing mostly only theaters, mostly theaters anyway, and we'd have, each week we were in a different town, and we'd have an eight o'clock rehearsal in the theater and they'd have people like Larry Adler, who is my biggest nightmare because he was playing all these "Rhapsody in Blue" and Ravel's "Bolero" and I couldn't read note one. So I was faking everything. In fact the first band I was with was a guy named Bob Astor's band, and we

had a kid on trumpet named Neal Hefti, who was writing arrangements for the band, and Bob would say every Monday he had to bring in an arrangement for Tuesday rehearsal see, or Monday rehearsal, whatever. And during the week he'd say "Neal, how are you doing with the arrangement?" Neal would say "you'll have it in time, don't worry." Came Monday for the rehearsal, he never got to the rhythm section. He wouldn't finish the arrangement, because he couldn't write a score.

MR: Oh, he just wrote the parts individually.

MN: What he did was, Neal Hefti was rooming with Shelly Manne the drummer. And Shelly used to complain because Neal didn't know how to write a score, so he would whistle the arrangement, the entire arrangement from the introduction, chorus, modulation, out choruses, background choruses, everything he would whistle, each part, and after he finished the lead trumpet he would throw it on the floor and look at it, and harmonize it. [Whistles] He was whistling all night long, and Shelly used to call him "the whistler" — he said, "he drove me crazy," in fact at night he'd have all these parts on the floor and I would get up to go to the bathroom and he'd say "watch it, Shelly, you're stepping on my baritone." He says I felt like I was walking through a cow pasture there. It was unbelievable. And Neal and I were one day coming down in an elevator in the hotel going to work, and he said to me you know what my biggest thrill would be in life? My ambition, that's what he said, "my ambition is to someday write for the Count Basie Orchestra." Do you think he achieved his goal?

MR: I guess so. You know it might have been an advantage for you that he didn't get to the piano part, because he might have written something very difficult, if you weren't a reader at the time.

MN: Well actually what happened was he would pass out the parts at the rehearsals see, and the bass player's name was Marty too. See? Well he was Marty Two, I was Marty One, and Shelly was the drummer, and he would give us blank manuscripts and he would say "Shelly, Marty Bass and Marty Piano." The only reason we knew it was piano was because in the left hand side it said "Piano," and the manuscript was empty. And I'd say "hey Neal, when are you going to write me a part? I'm trying to learn how to read music." So anyway, to get back to Chico, I couldn't read. I hadn't learned yet, because I was like scuffling. So when we got to Chico's band and I was like playing these shows

with comedians and dancers, I was lucky that we had an 18 piece orchestra. And fortunately I had what they called a piano/conductor part. And on the top, in red ink, was what the lead trumpet was playing, see? So now I would fake through the first show and from the second show on I would follow the red notes on the piano sheets see? And I would notice like whenever the band had an eighth rest and a dotted quarter, I know it always went [scats] and I said, hey that's great, you know. By the time I left that band I was reading music.

MR: That's fascinating. And that must have been standard procedure for those arrangers back then to put the trumpet part in red?

MN: Well no it wasn't that, it was the people who had the act, like the dance team or the comedian or the harmonica player, whoever, they would hand out their parts. It wasn't the orchestra parts, it was the parts from the act that we were playing.

MR: I see.

MN: Because when they didn't know they would say well this is the drummer's part, and this is the saxophone players, and this is the piano/conductor, because the piano player was usually the conductor. And they would say piano/conductor. So I was lucky because all of those things had those red lines, those red music dots on there, and that's how I learned how to read. In fact the funny thing was, only about three years ago, my wife and I were sitting in the living room and I said, "well you know I scuffled during Chico's band because I couldn't read." She said, "you didn't know how to read when you were with Chico's band?" She never even knew I couldn't read. Because we were too busy, we had just gotten married, we were busy doing something else.

MR: And that was what year?

MN: 1942, February. I joined them February of '42.

MR: Now you having come from a musical family—

MN: Exactly.

MR: —can I assume that it was okay with your parents that you were going into this field?

MN: As a matter of fact that's funny you lead me into that. Because when I started going with my wife, I met my wife when we were both 18 years old. Obviously we were the same age just about. And we kept company for about two years. But after about a year, my father said to me "you can't keep company with that girl." I said, "why not?" He says,

"you're planning on marrying her?" I said, "yeah." He said, "well you can't even think about that." I said, "why?" He said, "she's going to keep you away from studying the piano." How would you like to have parents like that?

MR: Wow. That's a turnaround.

MN: Well see you talk about a musical family?

MR: Really.

MN: My father played banjo and guitar, my mother played guitar, I had two brothers and two sisters. My brother Teddy was a piano player, my brother Andy was a drummer, both of my sisters were singers. My sister Margaret married a piano player named Shorty Allen, and my sister Josephine married a saxophone player named Bill Shine. Fantastic lead alto man. And my grandfather, my father's father, played guitar, and my aunt — he was living with his daughter Josephine until he died, and she says the day he died he was sitting with the guitar in his hand, strumming the guitar. And then his father played guitar. So it went way back with the guitars and the music. And everybody, in fact when I started this project with the book, people used to say to me, "how many musicians in your generation, your family are musically inclined, or jazz or whatever." I'd say, "I don't know." I started counting them and I got to 50 and I lost count. Because not only my family, but my mother's side.

MR: Well your uncle—

MN: Phil. Right.

MR: Trumpet.

MN: See the thing, to start it off this way, I usually start off my interviews by saying my father was the oldest of five brothers and one sister. All of the boys were professional musicians. And my father was the oldest, and he played banjo and guitar, my uncle Georgie, George Napoleon played the saxophone, my uncle Teddy was a drummer, my uncle Joey was a saxophone player — and who else, there were five brothers — Pop, Georgie, Teddy, Joey—

MR: And Phil?

MN: And Phil, right, I forgot. All musicians. Now before my uncle Phil Napoleon passed away, he called me about once every week and a half or two weeks, like that. He would call me because he wanted me to have the cemetery plots, he wanted to leave them to me

because I was the last surviving Napoleon on his side. And he would tell me stories about my father. And he said, "you know when your father was about 18 years old, 19, 18, he bought a trumpet because he wanted to play the trumpet. And he started a jazz club like I forget the name of it now, he told me what the name is I can't remember, the Arrowsmith or the Arrow Club. And they used to chip in dues to belong to this jazz club, it was a club, you know, a society? And he said he used to put the trumpet in a closet on one of the shelves, and Phil was about five years old and he found the trumpet one day. And he started fooling with it. Next thing he was getting sounds, and my father caught him one day playing, about a year later, and he says, "I'm going to switch to guitar," he says, or banjo, because he says, "I could never do what you're doing." And he was five years old. So what happened was my father used to do dates, and he would bring Phil with him on the job, at five years old. And during the course of the evening he would make an announcement about his kid brother, and put a chair in the middle of the floor, and put him on that chair and he would play the trumpet. People went absolutely bananas.

MR: Wow. The little Mozart.

MN: Yeah, he was great.

MR: Well your career started when the big bands were pretty healthy.

MN: Right.

MR: And you obviously did marry your wife.

MN: Obviously.

MR: Well it's stood the test of time anyway.

MN: Oh boy I'm telling you. And then we went back to my mother's house after we got married, she lived a block away, and we had a sandwich and a glass of milk and my wife walked me to the subway, and I went back to Pennsylvania, and I finished two weeks with the band, and I did my honeymoon alone in Buffalo. I said, "man, nobody's had a honeymoon like this." I spent my honeymoon alone man.

MR: In Buffalo.

MN: In Buffalo.

MR: In the winter.

MN: It's cold.

MR: My God.

MN: It was cold. I can't believe how cold it gets in Buffalo. And anyway, that's what happened. So listen to this, now here's another funny story. I get back to New York and now we're married, so we check into the Forrest Hotel, and the band that I was with has some time off, so we get married and we checked into the Forrest Hotel on 48th Street in New York, and about three o'clock in the morning the phone rings. Four o'clock in the morning. And I can't even find the phone, it's like on the floor or something. I said, "hello?" "Who's this?" "Marty, this is Shelly Manne." I says, "what's happening, Shelly?" He says, "we're having a jam session at the Capitol Hotel in the ballroom." I says, "I'll be right there." So I hung up the phone, and my wife says, "where you going?" I says, "Shelly said they're having a session." So she says, "you're not going without me." So we got our clothes on, we went over there, and about 30 years later I'm doing a club date, a Jewish wedding someplace, and the drummer was a club date leader. He says, "Marty, do you know when you got married you went to a jam session at the Capitol Hotel." I said, "how'd you know that?" He says, "I was playing drums." And he says, "you know what? I looked over and your wife was sitting in the corner by you on the piano, falling asleep." He says, "how dare you?" And my wife says, "yeah, if I knew he was going to do that, that would have been it, that would have been it."

MR: You know I think some script writer must have known about that because that's the scene in the Glenn Miller story in the movie.

MN: Oh yeah?

MR: He gets married, he goes back to the hotel and all the guys show up at this thing and they go down and they hear Louis Armstrong.

MN: I've got a picture here of that, when we did that scene. I've got a picture in the book. It was strange, I'll tell you. But it was great, and funny, when I did get married, and I told my father we got married and he gave me a can opener. He said, "here, you're going to need this?" I said, "what are you kidding? My wife's going to be a great cook." Because she had never cooked before. She was a dressmaker and she used to go to work every day, and she used to come home and her mother had dinner for her see? He says to me "here. You're going to need this." And she says, "how dare your father, he said I was going to need a can opener?" So we went on the road, and instead of staying in hotels, there was a trombone player named Chuck Maxon with Chico Marx's band. He and his

wife were married ten years, and he was old hand at being on the road. So we kind of hung out because his wife and my wife became very good friends. And she'd say, "don't stay in the hotel," the whole band would go in the hotel — he'd say we won't stay in the hotel, we'll stay in hotels with — what do they call them, kitchenettes. You know because we're going to be in each town for a week. So rather than just spend rent money, we could cook and you'd save some money. And my wife learned how to cook that way. It was great, I loved it. It was just a fascinating story. And people ask me these questions all the time about my life on the road. When I tell them these stories, my wife says, "you're a blabbermouth" because I never stop. I say "I can't help it, I just love it." I love talking about it because everybody's fascinated by what we went through. I mean there are stories that are incredible.

MR: Did it get to the point where you had had enough of it?

MN: Never.

MR: Never.

MN: Oh until now. The only reason I don't work as much as I did now is my wife isn't feeling well. So I decided hey, I've been on the road over 50 years and she's waiting for me all this time, now I'm going to spend some time with her, and that's why I carry my phone with me all the time, to keep track of her. My daughter's calling, keep track, she's got her girlfriend sitting with her. She's not well at all.

MR: Well you have played with an amazing list of people.

MN: Did you see that list I gave you?

MR: Yes, I'm looking at it now. I have my own little sheet here too.

MN: Oh you have your own thing, I see.

MR: Joe Venuti? Some really marvelous — not only musicians but characters.

MN: Joe Venuti himself was a character. Unbelievable. I was telling a story just the other day about Joe Venuti. We played Palisades Park. Do you remember that name at all?

MR: Sure.

MN: Palisades Park? Well when we played Palisades Park in New Jersey, Cliffside, someplace, and we used to do on Saturdays a matinee, and right across the park was an Italian restaurant. And we'd go there for dinner. And Joe knew the bosses, which didn't matter anyway, but we would sit there and he would tell us stories, and we did more

laughing than eating because he was a very funny guy. There were stories about Joe Venuti that you don't believe, and I've got some in my book that are incredible. About one where we were working at a park in Lincoln, not Nebraska, Lincoln Park in Massachusetts someplace, Bedford, Mass. Anyway, it was an outdoor park, it was an amusement park, and it was September and we were freezing. Guys were wearing overcoats and gloves. I was playing piano with gloves on, so was Joe.

MR: Joe, with the violin.

MN: No he took a chair and he broke it up and he said to the band, "go buy some weenies," and the kid went to the store to buy the weenies and he came back and Joe took the chair and broke it up and built a fire on the bandstand. Then he took the weenies like this and he was sitting there while the band was playing and the kids were dancing, and he was roasting hot dogs, see? And the manager came running, and was furious. Because the kids, instead of dancing, they came around to watch the band. He says, "what the hell is this guy doing?" He's cooking frankfurters. So the manager went crazy. He says, "what are you doing? Well Joe was very cool you know, and he used to look at you this way and bite his lip saying, "what's wrong, whatsa matter?" The guy says, "what's wrong? You've got a fire on the bandstand." He says, "well the guys are freezing man, I'm trying to feed them, because we're cold." So he says, "you broke my chair." Joe he got up and put his hand up and says, "how much was the chair?" He was going to pay for the chair. He was crazy. But he had such great stories, I'm telling you. I've got some stories in my book about him you won't believe. You just don't believe man.

MR: When was your first opportunity to record?

MN: I think the first, well the first professional record date I did was I was working at Childs' Paramount Restaurant on Broadway and 43rd Street. It was downstairs from the Paramount Theater. Do you remember the Paramount Theater where Frank Sinatra had that whole thing with the bobby soxers? There was a restaurant downstairs called Childs' Paramount, and I was working with Henry's band, and I got a call from a guy named Teddy Reig, who was a, did you know that name?

MR: Yeah, a big producer.

MN: Savoy Records, Guild Records, whatever. And he called me and my first record date was, are you ready for this? My first record date, Kay [sic] Winding, or Kai as he was known later, Shelly Manne, Ed Safranski, and Allen, boy, I just drew a blank.

MR: Sax player? Allen Eager?

MN: Yes. How did you know that? Well you should know that. And Allen Eager. And what happened was the gig became a fiasco, I hate to say this, but because of Allen Eager. Because he was like a negative personality. Because Kai would say "hey what are we going to play? How about —" And the guys were making suggestions. Like why don't we play this, why don't we play this. Everything was said, Allen would say "no man, don't play that." So we tried to please him and say "all right we'll play that." Nobody really wanted to play the tunes he wanted, but they were trying to appease him. And everybody wound up like this. And I did a three hour interview for Phil Schaap on WKCR. And he played two of those records. I said, "I thought there was only one, called 'Olgamore.'" He said, "no, there's another one." And I listened to it and I said now I know why I don't have the other one. It's terrible. You know it was the beginning of the bebop thing and everybody is [scats], with flatted fifths and all that. And it was really terrible. I mean you've got great musicians like this. But it wasn't very good. Plus the fact that there was so much tension at that date. We went in at about one o'clock in the morning and we played until about twelve noon the next day, and they only put that one record out, two sides or whatever it was, and we never got paid for the overtime. So I saw Teddy Reig about 30 years later, I says, "hey Teddy, you know I never got any overtime for that date?" He says, "here, here's ten dollars." He gave me ten dollars out of his pocket.

MR: Well it's interesting that a lot of recording at that time must have been pretty much off the cuff. You get the musicians together and then you decide what you're going to play.

MN: Oh that's what it was. So everything was mostly head arrangements, that's how they started those heads. But the thing was, what was bad about it was the promoters, who knew nothing about music, but they just happened to know the musicians, they would get them in the studio and they would say "just make something up." And they would make something up and then somebody would come up with a name for the song, and the guys

would never get any royalties for it. So now there's a couple of guys, friends of mine now, they're let me see, Dean Pratt and Don Sickler. Do you know those names?

MR: Don Sickler I recognize.

MN: Don Sickler is a publisher and he's got this music composer's something, and they look out for royalties for musicians who've been getting screwed over the years, not getting their just desserts. And they're beautiful, because they look out for musicians and make sure they get what they're supposed to get you see? So that's what happened. A lot of those little things where the guys made up a little head arrangement and nobody ever saw any money for it, except the guy who was running the record company.

MR: What would a record date like that pay?

MN: In those days, for a three hour session, forty-one and a quarter. $41.25.

MR: You do have a pretty good memory.

MN: I remember everything, I swear.

MR: How about when you were first married and you were on the road? What kind of salary were you getting?

MN: Well that's a long story. You see when I left Bob Astor's band, before I left Bob Astor's band we were working in Youngstown, Ohio at the Elms Ballroom. And we were there for four weeks. And there was a local theater where bands used to come in and play, and what's his name, Ray McKinley and Wilbur, the trombone player, now the age is catching me. Ray McKinley and Will Bradley, Bradley-McKinley, you know, 18th and Chestnut, between 18th and 19th on whatever, you know. Anyway, they came into town. They were thinking of splitting up. So I told Will Bradley, Will Bradley came to the Elms Ballroom and he heard us play and he flipped out. And he took some of us on the side on one of the breaks and he said, "you know Ray McKinley and I are breaking up," and he says, "you guys are great, and I'm starting a new band and I'd love to have you guys with me." And we said, "yeah," because we were like young kids, it was the first band. You get an offer from a guy like Will Bradley, you say "I'm ready, I'm ready." So what happened, we went back to New York, the band had some time off, we went back to New York and I went to the rehearsal. And now the piano player with Will Bradley's band was a fellow named Billy Maxted. He wrote all the arrangements. In fact he wrote the arrangements with Chico Marx's band see? So he wrote the arrangements for Bradley's

band, and when Bradley wanted us to join his band, most of the guys with Astor's band went with him, including me, but the thing was that Billy Maxted, when I went to the rehearsal he was playing piano and he says, "I'm not leaving the band until I get my money, because he owes me a lot of money for arrangements, see, and when I get my money I'll call you, and you take my place." I says okay. So in the meantime I used to go to Local 802. First we'd go to Local 802 to look for jobs, and then we would go to Nola Studios, where all the musicians used to hang out. And Nola Studios, did you ever hear of that name? Nola Studios? It was on Broadway and 52nd Street, 51st Street, upstairs where now there's a hair, they teach girls how to make hair, whatever. And this place was huge. It was the whole floor, from 51st to 52nd Street, they had about twelve different studios, rehearsal studios. Every band that came into town rehearsed at Nola Studios. Bands would come into town— And every room had a door with a mail slot in it. So we would go up there if somebody was rehearsing, we'd look in the mail slot to see who was rehearsing, and try and sneak in and listen to the band. So I came up there one day and there was a girl receptionist, Ella Jean, and I said, "hey Ella Jean, who's rehearsing today?" So I heard this music as I got out of the elevator, a big band coming from that room. And I said, "who's in that room, the band sounds great." She said, "Chico Marx." I said, "the Marx Brothers?" She said, "no not the Marx brothers, just Chico, the piano player." I said, "oh that's great." So I went over to the door to peek in the door to see what I could see. And as I went to open the slot, the door opened and somebody walked out and I snuck in. So I closed the door quietly and as I'm standing there, somebody in the band says, "hey Benny, there he is now." And the whole band is looking at me. And there's nobody in the room but the orchestra and me. So I gave it the old classic, "who, me?" So this guy comes over to me and he says, "hey, are you Marty Napoleon?" I said, "yeah, how did you know that?" He said, "we called your house, your wife said you went to the union." I said, "yeah I was at the union and I just came over here to see who was rehearsing." I said, "who are you?" He says, "I'm Ben Pollack, I'm the manager of the Chico Marx band." He says, "would you like to try out for the band?" I says, "what?" Because see he called Maxted, because the piano player gave his notice. Benny called Billy Maxted. Maxted said, "call this kid" because he had my number. He said, "call him" so he called my house and my wife said, "he went to the union."

MR: And then you walked in the door.

MN: And I walked in the door.

MR: That's really weird.

MN: I'm telling you, there are fantastic stories. So he says, "would you like to try out?" Now I'd just left Bob Astor's band where I couldn't read this many notes. You know I didn't know how to read music. So I went over, and he says, "do you want to try out?" I says, "yeah." I couldn't remember, everything was a blur. I didn't remember seeing guys sitting in the band, nothing. All I saw was a piano and music, when they put the music out, and it had real chords written out. It didn't have—

MR: No symbols?

MN: No symbols. It had real chords, like charts with chords. So when I sat down I just blacked out. I looked at that and I said forget it, it's not going to happen. But since I had such a good ear from the time I was like six years old or whatever, or from birth, the band started to play and I played along with them. Now I found out later — first Benny comes over to me after I'd played a few numbers with the band, and he says, "okay, kid, you got the job." And I'm saying why would this guy hire me? I mean I couldn't hardly play, I couldn't read, I didn't know anything. He says, "You got the job. You get 75 bucks a week and we leave Monday for Philadelphia." So I called my wife and I said, "Honey, quit your job, we're going on the road." She says, "get out of here, what are you talking about?" So I told her what happened. She said, "I don't believe it. What are you talking about?" You know why she was incredulous? Because I had spoken to my father when I left Bob Astor's band, I said, "pop, I'm married, I know I'm going to have some kids, I can't read, I'm not too good a piano player, I've got to support my wife." He says, "don't worry, I know somebody at Wheeler's Shipyard, I'll get you a letter of introduction." And I carried that letter of introduction for two weeks in my pocket. When I went to the union I had that letter in my pocket, I was going to go to the shipyard to get a job. So when I called my wife I said, "guess what? Quit your job." She was making forty bucks a week as a dressmaker. She said, "I'm not quitting my job, you're crazy." I said, "no honey, we're going on the road, and no wife of mine is going to work." I said, "I'm going to support the family." She said, "why, what are you going to get?" I said, "75 bucks a week." She almost died. I said, "hello?"

MR: That was good.

MN: Seventy-five, are you kidding?

MR: This was 194—

MN: '42. People were making 20 dollars a week, 30 dollars. So I went on the road, and I took my wife with me. She quit her job, she came on the road with me, and the rest is history. Six months later we were in Niagara Falls, well Buffalo, we were playing a theater there. And we played a split week which means when you play the theater date you played seven days. When you did a split week you did three days in one and three days in another and you had one day off because Sunday was like Blue Law days you know. So we had a day off, a Sunday off. So Chuck Max and his wife and my wife and I we rented a car and went to Niagara Falls. I said, "didn't I tell you I'd take you to Niagara Falls for your honeymoon?"

MR: There you go.

MN: So it was great, I loved it, it was beautiful.

MR: My goodness. And then you went on to Lee Castle and Charlie Barnet.

MN: Charlie Barnet. That was a story, Charlie Barnet's band. I was reading *Down Beat* magazine. You got your own list —

MR: I've got my own list here.

MN: Do you know about all these things? Oh you must have gotten it from what?

MR: I did some research.

MN: Leonard Feather huh?

MR: Yeah, and the *Grove Dictionary*.

MN: *Grove Dictionary*, right okay. Anyway so the Charlie Barnet thing was like I was sitting at home, I had just left Teddy Powell's band or Lee Castle's band. Teddy Powell's band I think. That's another story, that Teddy Powell was weird. Because in Teddy Powell's band, we had Charlie Ventura on the band, it was magnificent. And Teddy loved him and he used to have arrangements written for Charlie that Charlie would play. He would feature him, and he'd play the introduction [scats] and when he got a call from Gene Krupa was starting another band, so he called Charlie and he says, "Charlie I'm starting a symphonic orchestra," he says, "you got it." So he gave his notice to Teddy. In fact Charlie says to me, "I got a call from Gene and he needs a piano player and I told him

about you, I says, "see if he wants to come with the band." And I said, "oh I'd love to but my brother Teddy's in New York, I don't think he's working and I've got a job." So he says, "you would do that for your brother?" I said, "hey he's my brother man. I've got a job with Teddy Powell, so call my brother." And he called my brother and he was available and he took the job, he went with Gene. So now Teddy takes the job with Gene and I'm with Powell's band, oh then when Charlie gave his notice, we're doing a date in a ballroom someplace in Milwaukee or someplace, no it doesn't matter, St. Louis, Missouri, I remember everything, and Charlie's doing his solo up front, and Teddy used to walk back and forth while he was playing his solo, and some kid says, "hey Teddy, man, he's fantastic." And I'm listening to him, he's standing by the piano see. So he says, "you think he's great, wait until you hear the guy I've got coming in, Teddy Nash." First he's great, then he's not that good because he gave his notice. So that's the kind of guy he was. So now I gave my notice, because he was getting on my nerves for some reason I forget. So I look at my itinerary. I gave a two week notice, and on the 14th day of my notice, no the 13th day of my notice we have a day off in New York City, and the 14th day of my notice is in Toronto, Canada. Now when you give your notice to a band on the road, and you quit, you have to pay your way home. If he fires you he pays your transportation home. So I went to him and I said, "hey Teddy, you know I notice on the 13th day we have a day off in New York City, why don't you get a piano player to start in Toronto." He says, "oh no, you gave a two week notice and your date is—" So I said, I've got to get away from this band. So I quit the band. So anyway one little thing about Teddy Powell and Chico Marx was that Chico Marx was a fantastic man. He wouldn't go to dinner alone, he would always take a group of guys from the band with him. He loved to eat with a group of people. And he always paid for everything. I saved a lot of money that way you know. So when I went with Teddy Powell's band, the first night on the job after the job the guys went to get some hamburgers and things, and when the waitress came with the check he says, "I'll take it." So he took the check and he says, "you owe me sixty cents." I said, "hey Teddy, that ain't the way it's supposed to go.

MR: That's not what I'm used to.

MN: So anyway, with Charlie Barnet, I'm reading a *Down Beat* magazine and they've got a review of Charlie Barnet's band in California someplace, he was playing the Palladium or

someplace, and I read the names of the guys in the band, like Barney Kessel and all these different people, guys that I know. And I said to my wife gee I'd like to play with that band you know. And the next day I get a call from a guy named — the next day — I get a call from Jimmy Lamar, a saxophone player. He didn't go with the band but Charlie had contacted him to get some guys for the Strand Theater in New York, he was going to be there for eight weeks, eight or nine weeks. "Marty?" "Yeah." "Jimmy Lamar." "Hey, Jimmy, how are you?" He said, "listen, would you like to work with Charlie Barnet's band?" I said, "get out of here, give me that again, for real?" He says, "yeah, why?" I said, no it's too long a story. "Okay you've got it. Where is he going?" "Strand Theater." I said, man, boom, just like that, eight weeks. Now we're at the Strand, Gene Krupa goes into the Capitol Theater around the corner, with his band, and my brother, and we're running between theaters like to see each other between shows you know. It was great.

MR: What great times.

MN: Oh it's a fabulous life, man, I love it.

MR: Can you put this in perspective for me a little bit? The music that you were playing at that time, what was the average age of the audience that would come to see you?

MN: The audience? I'd say anywhere from 18 to 25, 30, somewhere around there. They were young kids. You know this is something that you mention, funny you mention that because I keep thinking about the fact that the music that we loved then, excuse me, with the big band, it was like jazz tinged. Everything was jazz flavored. Nowadays they've got these 18 year old kids, listening to rap or whatever other stuff they're listening to, and I say what happened to these kids, when we were 18, that when they heard the Glenn Miller band or a Charlie Barnet or a Count Basie or a Duke Ellington, they went crazy. Don't these kids have the same kind of feeling that we did in those days?

MR: That was the popular music of the day, what you were playing.

MN: But that's beside the point. The point is even today, you listen to a Glenn Miller arrangement, and the music is so melodic and so beautiful. I mean I remember even when Buddy DeFranco was fronting the Glenn Miller band a friend of mine called me and he says, "Marty, would you like to go see the Glenn Miller band?" I says, "where? He's dead." He said, "no, but Buddy DeFranco's got the band, they're going to be at St. Regis Roof." I said, "I'd love to." He says, "you're my guest." And we went up there and I

swear to you the band, I mean the kids in the band were like 18, 19 years old, young kids because he couldn't afford to get older guys. When the band started to play the theme I had a lump in my throat and I got tears in my eyes. Because I said, "I don't care how you feel about the band, the music was so beautiful and so romantic and so melodic. And I don't understand these kids today. Don't they hear a melody? I mean can't they hear something when it makes sense?

MR: Well I have a small theory about that.

MN: What?

MR: And I think that the parts of the music that get the emphasis has changed a lot. And you mentioned there, the melodic end of it. That's what you heard, but as soon as you heard that theme song you heard the melodic end of it. But I think starting in the 50s and so forth it switched to the rhythmic end of it a lot more. And when you say rap, that's almost total rhythm. It's almost total rhythm.

MN: It's not music.

MR: Well to their ears it's music but it's almost totally rhythmic and also even the way they make the records now, the rhythm is so much out there, farther than any melody that might even be there.

MN: Well maybe I'm prejudiced, I can't fathom listening to something when it doesn't have melodic lines, they're just talking it. I mean that's like Phil Harris talking "Sixteen Tons." Remember that song? "Sixteen Tons." Or Rex Harrison doing "My Fair Lady." I mean he did a great job, but he wasn't singing a song. I want to hear — Bobby Darin, you know, who is my favorite singer.

MR: A quick question about the union. It seemed like they had a fairly together system about, you just don't walk out on a band, with the business of having to give two weeks. Let's suppose you walked out on a band. What was the — what could happen to you?

MN: Well you could get fired.

MR: But would you lose your union card?

MN: I don't know it's never happened to me. And I don't know anybody that it's ever happened to. But I mean if you were working, like say for instance you're traveling on the road with a band?

MR: Yeah.

MN: Well I guess that's a matter of a personal thing between the leader and whoever is walking out on the band. Maybe the band leader would say good riddance, I wanted to get rid of him anyway so the guy quit, good riddance. Or he might say "oh you can't do that to me," like Teddy Powell said, "no you gave a two week notice which means you've got to go 14 days." And the 13th day was a day off, I had to go to Toronto. And I was making like $130 a week or something, and I had to pay my own carfare back from Toronto, which was ten, twenty dollars, but it hurt me in the pocket, see? And I said why couldn't he say I'll get a piano player in New York? He was in New York. He could have made a phone call to his agent or somebody who was booking the band and say get me a piano player in New York and have them meet us up in Toronto. Simple. There were so many guys in those days, my God everybody was there.

MR: Well he was probably in a bad mood because Charlie was leaving at the same time, and he said I'll take it out on you.

MN: Charlie had already left I think. But that band was great. We had a marvelous player. We had a guy named Boots Mussulli, and Boots was my roommate and he would say to me, he had to write an arrangement a week for the band, and he'd say "what do you want me to write?" He didn't know what to— I'd say "why don't you do 'Perdido'?" "Good, I'll put a solo in there for you." I'd say of course. He was beautiful. We had Pete Condoli with the band, Milt Bernhardt, two brothers, the Brooks brothers, lead trumpet and lead trombone. They were fantastic. Larry Brooks and I forget the trumpet player's name. These guys were great. And who else did we have? Charlie Ventura, we had some good guys — all I know is good men. And we used to go up to Boston a lot and play the Raymour Playmore Ballroom, and, who am I talking about? Teddy Powell's band?

MR: I think you were.

MN: Oh Teddy Powell's band. Forgive me, it's my age. But we used to play the Raymour Playmore Ballroom in Boston. And in those days every band had to do a waltz set, play a waltz occasionally, and we would play the waltzes and Charlie Ventura would say "A flat," and we'd play [scats]. We'd play "Mairzy Doats," as a waltz, and it was great. It was great, Charlie was great. And the kids, they realized that Teddy Powell didn't have any talent, and they used to come to us and say "you know this is one of the best bands

we've ever heard of in this ballroom. Can't you get rid of that guy up front?" We said, "no, he's the leader, he put us together."

MR: Well that wasn't the only band that that was the case with, was it?

MN: I always used to say if a guy doesn't have talent he books them and he leads the band. Except for guys like Benny Goodman and Tommy Dorsey and people like that.

MR: When we look back on those times now, the end of World War II and we're able to say okay well that was the demise of the big band, did you guys in the bands get a sense of what was happening at the time?

MN: With the war?

MR: Well when did the business start to go downhill or to change for you guys?

MN: Well to tell you the truth, in my youth I wasn't very intelligent. All I had in my mind was playing the piano. I didn't think politically, I didn't think musically — well musically actually just for the band that I was playing with. And I didn't know what was going on in the world actually. I wasn't aware of all of those things. All I knew is I had to support a wife and a kid, and this is what basically took up time in my head. But funny you should say — the end of the war, I just looked at my book the other night and I noticed on 1945 when the war ended I was playing with Charlie Barnet's band. We were playing someplace out in the midwest in an airplane hangar. I just read that the other day. Isn't that incredible? I said look at where I was, with Charlie's band, when the war ended. And we played a victory dance that night. It was great. But speaking about the war, with Charlie Barnet's band we went, when we left New York, when we finished at the Strand Theater in New York, I had to make a decision because my daughter was just a year and a half old, and the manager said, "we're going to go California." I said, "gee I don't know if I want to make that trip, I've got a wife and a little kid." He says, "well you know every time we go to California, Charlie likes to sit down for about a year or more. I said, "that sounds good," because he lived in Sherman Oaks, California, and when he got back to California he liked to sit there a while. In other words he was on the road then he comes home and he sits. So I said to my wife, and we had to make a decision, we were saying what should we do? In 1942 I was like 23 years old. And we said well let's go. So we decided to go with the band. It was rough. Man, I'm telling you, I don't know how, my wife and I think back and say how did we do it. We had the baby, of course we were

so young and stupid. Because if we had any brains we'd have said are you crazy? I'm going to carry my daughter on the bus on one-nighters?

MR: Well as time passed, eventually you got to work with your uncle?

MN: Yes, my Uncle Phil. And that's a funny story too, because he had really a great Dixieland band, and I couldn't play Dixieland one, not one note. So my brother-in-law, Shorty Allen, the piano player, he's married to my sister, and the four of us and somebody else, I forget who was with us, we went to New York to see "Some Like it Hot." And when we came out we said let's go see Uncle Phil at Nick's. He was working at Nick's. So we go to see him at Nick's. Now Phil, he knew that Shorty and I were like considered bebop piano players, because we didn't know from Dixieland. So he felt so funny because he said, "Either one of you guys want to sit in?" Hoping we'd say no, no, we can't play that kind of music. So I said, "Shorty, go ahead, why don't you play." So Shorty says, "Okay." So he went and sat in and played, and the next set Phil says now I've got to ask my nephew, right. Marty you want to sit in? I said, yeah, all right, okay. So I sat and he says, "what do you want to play?" I says, "Phil, I don't know your routines, your songs, your repertoire." I said, "pick a song." He says, "How about 'Back Home Again in Indiana.'" I said bing — I know that one. So we started playing "Back Home Again in Indiana" and luckily he played it [scats] not too fast, see it was like slow. Which means when it got to my solo, when I took a piano solo, just because I was in Rome I figured let me do this, and he turns around at me and he says oh yeah? Because I'm figuring well I've got to make the guy happy anyway. So I'm going [scats] and he turned around and he's slapping the piano like this. So when we finished the set he comes over to me and he says, "Marty come over here I'm going to talk to you." I knew right away what he was going to say see? And I was going to say yes, because I wanted to learn how to play some Dixieland. Sure enough he took me in the corner and he says, "I didn't know you could play like that." I says, "I don't." He said, "well I just heard you." I said, "Phil, that was for you," because I didn't want you to say bebop piano players see? So I said, "I think I would like that." So I took the band — I took the job with the band. That's how I wound up with his band.

MR: The Memphis Five was it called?

MN: It was called the Memphis Five. It was a great band. But a funny thing is, we went up to Boston for two weeks and we played at Mrs. Donahue's place, it was great, and he and I had a little falling out because he had Sol Yaged on clarinet, a young kid about 19 years old, Dick Brady on trombone, Tony Spargo on drums, who was fantastic. Did you ever hear that name?

MR: No.

MN: From the old New Orleans Rhythm Kings, rhythm something.

MR: Oh, that Tony.

MN: Tony Spargo. His real name was Barbaro but he changed it to Spargo because everybody couldn't say Barbaro. And Tony Spargo, he used to play the kazoo when he played a solo, and he would like he had a big Chinese crash cymbal. Boy he had great time. [scats] and man I used to jump off the stool, I said this guy's great, I loved it. But anyway what happened was there was a bass player, his name was Bob Carter. Actually he had a long Hawaiian name, but he changed it to Carter because nobody could ever say his name, and he was blind. He had been temporarily blinded during the war. And I met him when he was working on 52nd street with Charlie Ventura and Bill Harris and they had a little group, and I got to meet him, we got to be good friends, and he'd say to me every time I met him, he recognize my voice and say "Marty, get me a gig, get me a gig." So when Phil called me, when I was to rehearse with the band he said, "I need a bass player." So I called Bob and I said, "hey Bob, I've got a gig for you." He says, "get outta here." And guess what, he says, "I got my sight back."

MR: Oh wow.

MN: I says, "you're kidding." He says, "yeah, it was a temporary thing, it was shock like." But he says but there's still a little thing in the center of his eyes that had to clear up yet see? I said, "beautiful, man." So I got him on the band. But he was like a real [scats]. So I said but you've got to play two/four. He says, "I don't care I'll play anything." So anyway he comes on the band, now we're in Boston, we're playing, and the band was just fantastic, it was a great Dixieland band, but every time a trombone solo, clarinet solo or piano solo, the guy's like [scats]. So Phil says, "Marty, I want to talk to you." So we went outside and we had a discussion on the sidewalk for about half an hour man. He was saying you know he went into an oration, a long one, about you know I didn't make my name in

music without the fact that it's jazz Dixieland because they love me because we play Dixieland, and you guys are playing four/four swing. And I said Phil, we're not trying to disrespect you or anything. This is how we feel. We're young guys and we like to play, I mean we'll play what you want, we're playing for you, don't we — we went through a long, long thing and I finally convinced him I said, "we love what you're doing, we love playing with the band. If it comes out that way we can't help it, so what? How long does it last, a minute a half a minute? So he says yeah all right, okay, I don't care what you play as long as it's swinging like it is. And it got me off the hook see. And the band was just incredible, it was fantastic. So what happened was while we were there for those two weeks Mrs. Donahue was a beautiful lady, she invited us out to her house for dinner, and she said, "You guys like to golf?" I said, "I love to golf." She says, "You got any clubs?" I said, "No, I'm on the road." So Bob and I, he used to carry his clubs with him. We went golfing every day for two weeks, eight o'clock in the morning. When we finished the engagement I was paralyzed. Using muscles I hadn't used. So we come back to New York and my wife had to wash my face, put my pants on. I couldn't move. I was paralyzed. And now Phil called and he says, "We have to go and do two nights in Parris Island, North Carolina at the Marine place, you know that Parris Island? It's a Marine place, where there's Marines. Very famous. North Carolina. And we drove down there, and I drove with Bob in his car, all the way like this in the car. And he said, and I'm hanging on because my back is killing me, right? He says, "Incidentally, the doctor says even though I have my sight back, it could go off any minute." So I says, "Thanks a lot, you shouldn't tell me that while I'm in pain."

MR: You two guys were in great shape.

MN: So I mean these are stories that, you know when I do a club date or something and we sit in the back room, and the guys want to know these stories, they say "man, why don't you write a book?" I say "I wrote a book, nobody wants to publish it." I'm trying to get somebody to condense it because it's seven million pages long.

MR: Who were you listening to at the time? You considered yourself a bopper?

MN: Yeah, I'm sorry, go ahead.

MR: Did you listen to like Bud Powell?

MN: Oh sure. I mean in fact when they'd ask me questions, guys come to review the bands that I was with, they'd ask the guys individually, who's your favorite piano player, and I'd say well I like Oscar Peterson and Erroll Garner, Erroll was my favorite. Because he was a friend of mine. He used to send me Christmas cards. And one day my son found a Christmas card in the drawer. He said, "hey Dad." I said, "what?" "Erroll Garner?" I said, "what?" He says, "he sent you a Christmas card?" I said, "yeah I get one every year." He said, "man!"

MR: Wow, you're legitimate all of a sudden.

MN: He said, "I didn't know you were that famous." I said, "yeah, he's my friend." In fact he made a record of a thing called "That's My Kick." Did you ever hear it?

MR: No.

MN: He's got an introduction he must have been stoned when he did it because I don't know how he did that [scats]. It's like so erratic. I tried to notate it and I went crazy. I couldn't do it. So I saw him on the street one day I said, "hey Erroll, please, I'm trying to write down that kick." I said, "what did you do in that intro?" He says, "man, how am I supposed to know. Do you expect me to know that?"

MR: Well sure and if you had been able to write it down and give it to him to play it, he couldn't play it.

MN: Oh of course not but he was great. In fact we did an album together. Go ahead, ask me something.

MR: Well I have to get to Louis Armstrong.

MN: I know, they always do.

MR: And I see he was lucky enough to get his name on an album with you.

MN: That's a black market album you know, from Milano. And I had a friend of mine, I was working at Eddie Condon's on 54th Street one night, and I saw a friend of mine who was a distributor. Joe Muranyi sent me this, the clarinet player, he sent me this. He said, "I've got an album of you and Louis and Tyree." I said, "what do you mean? Send me the album." I said I can't believe this, it's double album, see? It's got our pictures inside and everything. But the reason I think they picked Tyree and me was because he and I were the only guys in the band who did an encore. See and when we did concerts with Louis, if you got an exceptionally big hand, they'd say do another chorus of that, Pops. Do an

encore, do something else. You could either do the same thing over, or play another song. So Tyree and I both got big enough hands that he would say do another song. So they figured in Italy, in Milano, they said these guys must be the big stars in the band, because they're the only ones that did an extra chorus. That's the only way I can figure it out. Because why would they do that? And that's a funny story. Was that after Charlie Barnet? No after Charlie Barnet I went with Gene Krupa's band.

MR: Yeah, you replaced your brother.

MN: Teddy, yeah. That's a funny story too, because I was working at Childs' Paramount with Henry Jerome's band. And there was a — oh a little ginger ale does it — and there was a club on Fifth Avenue and 43rd Street, called The 400 Club. And I was working with Henry up there, at 42nd Street and Broadway, and after the job I went to see Krupa's band because I knew they were working at this club. And when I walked in, the band, I don't know whether they had just taken a break or they had played the last number, something, but Joe Dale was the manager of the band. He was a drummer whenever Gene stood in front of the band he would play the drums, Joe Dale. So he came to me he says, "hey Marty, would you like to sit in with the band?" You know these things happen to you like you're taken aback. I said, "yeah, I'd love to." So I played a set with the band see? And when I got off Joe came to me and he says, "you know Gene likes you very much, would you like to join?" I said, "what are you kidding? My brother's with the band. I would never do that." He says, "no, he gave his notice" he was leaving the band. I said, "well I've got to find him." And you know I couldn't find my brother anywhere. I didn't know what happened to him. Maybe he got annoyed because I was sitting in, and he figured somebody's going to take his place, maybe some guy from left field would come in. Here's his own kid brother sitting up there. I don't really know. We never discussed it or anything. So anyway I took the job with the band, and I went with the band. And why did I say that story? Oh because—

MR: Yeah, we were talking about Krupa, this was 1945.

MN: '46, '46. Yeah. So anyway I went with the band and what happened was I know it broke my brother's heart because he was with the band for some time, and I go with the band and we went to California, we did two movies, a movie and a short. Now I know that broke his heart. What could I do? I didn't tell him to make a movie so I could be in it. So

I know that he was very distressed about that. I would have been too. It's like with me with Louis, I did the "Glenn Miller Story" but then when I left the band after traveling so much. One week we came from Norway or something and we went to Honolulu then we came back to Massachusetts and then they were going to Japan. I said, "I can't make it," I quit, I gave my notice. And I said I'm disturbed with Joe Glaser because he knew they were going to make "High Society," and he didn't say to me, "well why don't you hang in there because we're going to make—" so they made "High Society" and I don't want to look at that movie because I should have been on that movie. Because I gave my notice because we were doing so many big jumps: Europe, Hawaii, back and forth. I got so tired.

MR: The traveling was harder.

MN: I don't know how Louis did it. He loved it.

MR: Yeah, he never stopped.

MN: He just loved it. He loved being on the road more than he did living at home. He carried everything with him, anything he owned. He had 27 bags on the road. Yeah, we got off a plane once and we were waiting for a bus to take us to Carolina or something, and they stole my bag. I had a big clothes — my big luggage, Samsonite, I had a big Samsonite. And it was on the sidewalk with a thousand pieces of luggage. So some guy came and says, I think it might have been the red cap or something, "man how many guys in your band?" We said, "six guys." He said four thousand pieces of luggage! Well 27 are Louis'. He said 27? He carried everything on the road. And then I think we went to Georgia and when we got there my bag wasn't there, I lost my bag. Somebody just picked it up, there was a million bags, easy, right? Just grab one and walk away. That's what they did. So to get back to, where were we, with Krupa?

MR: Well with Louis. And he was pretty much controlled or under the thumb of Joe Glaser? Is that right? Or was he his own man?

MN: No he was his own man. No Louis used to say, I heard him say on many occasions, especially if he had a couple of beers, he'd say "three things in my life that matter to me: my horn, Joe Glaser and Lucille." And not necessarily in that order. I don't remember how he said it, but those are the things he thought about, that he cared about. Everything else, forget about it, I don't care. But people would say Louis made Joe Glaser rich. And

I say yeah, well Joe Glaser made Louie rich, too, because Joe Glaser would make some kind of deals with promoters, he'd say "you want Louis? You've got to book Red Norvo," or you've got to take so-and-so. He would make deals for different people. He was a sharp, smart promoter.

MR: So some of the other musicians profited from that association too.

MN: How do you mean?

MR: Well Red Norvo was getting more work because of Louis.

MN: Oh well I don't mean especially Red Norvo. He came to mind because he's the reason why I went with Louis. Not especially but when Joe Glaser called me, the first time he called me to go with Louis, it's a funny story because he said, "Marty this is Joe Glaser. Did you work with Phil Napoleon's Memphis Five?" I said, "yeah, why?" He said, "you play Dixieland?" I said, "I guess so, if I worked with Phil's band I guess." He said, "well you want to go with Louis Armstrong?" And I said, "no." He said, "did you hear what I said?" I said, "yeah, Louis Armstrong." He says, "you don't want to go with Louis?" I said, "no." Because of the fact that I had just left a group, now I didn't leave the group it broke up, I was with a quartet just before I went with Louis. I worked with Phil Napoleon then I went with a group called The Big Four. And we went to Chicago for two weeks and we stayed four months. And my wife was up to here. She said, "I'm going to leave you." Finally what happened was the group broke up and we came back to New York and that's when Joe Glaser called me. And I said, "No I can't Mr. Glaser." He says, "Why?" I said, well "You booked The Big Four." He was our manager/agent. And I said we were in Chicago for so long and my wife couldn't make it anymore. So I promised my wife when the group broke up I said no more road, honey. I made a vow to my wife, no more road. Because she said it's either me or the road. I said I prefer you so I'm home. So he says why don't you do this, why don't you come up and talk to me and we'll what happens." So I said, "Honey, I've got to go up and talk to him because I know Glaser for many years, he's a nice guy —. you never know maybe he'll get me a job someplace else to do whatever." So I went up to see him and Red Norvo was waiting to see him. He says, "What are you doing, Marty?" I said, "Glaser called me and wanted me to go with Louis' band." He says, "Great." I says, "Yeah but I don't want to go." He says, "What do you mean? You don't want to go with Louis?" So I told him what happened. I said I was with

The Big Four. We went to Chicago for two weeks and we stayed four months and my wife was ready to jump off a bridge. And so was I, I mean I was away so long. So I made a promise to her I said okay that's it, I'm not going on the road anymore. So he says, "Are you crazy?" He said, "look at what happened with Earl Hines." Earl had a big name but not as big as Louis. But when he went with Louis, they were equal and he was getting like equal publicity and stuff. Even though Louis was the boss, but Earl, it got him exposure, and then after a while he split and got his own group, now he's doing very well, he's going all over the world with his own group. And I'm listening to him like a jerk — not like a jerk because I went in and by the time I went inside Glaser said —. I says, "well okay."

MR: Ooh. That must have been a long trip home.

MN: Well of course I called my wife and said, "honey, guess what?" And she said, "You're kidding." She's been through, I'll tell you she's gone through a lot with me, really. She's been through a lot.

MR: You've got the road in your blood I guess.

MN: No not really. You know what I always say, like I remember once when I was very disappointed about playing club dates, like weddings and things like that, bar mitzvah's and that type, I said I think I'm going to give it up and — she says, "you going to quit the music business?" No she says, "I thought you like music?" I said, "Honey, I love music. I hate the music business. There's a difference.

MR: Well said.

MN: Because playing music, this is what happens with a lot of musicians. That's why these two guys formed this thing, so they can get musicians their royalties. Because guys, they love to play. Look how many times you go to the jam session, and the boss in the club loved it because he paid for a trio and got 18 guys on the bandstand. You know I played a million places like that where I'd have a trio and guys come in from all over the place. One guy brought his vibraphone and set them up on the front of the bandstand. One guy had a baritone, he put his case on the table and chair in the dining room. I says, "man, don't do that, put it on the bandstand." He says, "where?" But the bosses of course, they loved it. They had all these free musicians playing. Great. So anyway, but my wife has taken a lot from me all these years. But like I say I don't mind the traveling, I don't like

the road I guess is what it is. It's the buses and falling asleep in the bus. That's how I started wearing glasses. I never wore glasses. Because the guys in the bus would be sleeping and I'd have the little light on with a book and the thing going up and down like that. And after I while I said man I can't see the words anymore. So I lost my sight on the buses from reading.

MR: You got to go overseas with Louis' and other groups too?

MN: Well the other group was with Peanuts Hucko.

MR: Was there certain places that you've played that were particularly memorable overseas?

MN: Mostly all the places because especially, like I say, I wrote everything down. So I remember every place. One of the most exhilarating experiences was when we got to Switzerland, the first time I played in Switzerland. The first time I went into Europe with Louis was in October of 1952. '52 or '53. What? You don't remember?

MR: '52 '53 the first time around.

MN: Yeah okay. Anyway —

MR: Sweden, Denmark, Finland.

MN: Yeah the first place was Sweden, and we got into this town and the place was closed. There wasn't a thing in town. I met a guy and he could speak English and he spoke to me, "you with Louis Armstrong?" I says, "hey where is everybody?" He says, "what do you mean?" "I don't see anybody in the streets, nobody walking, the shops are closing." He says, "Louis Armstrong's here." I said, "what do you mean?" He said, "they closed the whole town," they were getting prepared to go see Louis at the concert. I swear to God, man. He said, "what do you mean, Louis Armstrong's here." I said oh, okay. So anyway it was Sweden, then we went to Denmark, then we were here and we traveled a lot, but it was so rough I'm telling you. Because we were doing not only like we'd play one country here today and then go to the next country, we would play two shows, one in the afternoon and one in the evening and sometimes a second one would even be in a different country. We got to Germany and this promoter, she was money hungry, she was trying to get as much out of Louis as she could. And we got to a town, I forget where it was, it might have been Munich, and we check into the hotel and we were so tired, because we had just gotten off a bus about 13 hours or so. And we checked in about 7:30 or quarter to 8. And 8:15 she was downstairs, "let's go, the concert's at 8:30." We had to

get back on the bus. And we just had time to put your bags down, wash your face, shave, and run downstairs. So I went past the dining room, and Arvell Shaw was sitting in the dining room. And I said how are we going to eat? He says, "man I've got to get something, I'm starving, I'm just having some soup." I said, "I'm going to do that too." So I sat down with him and I ordered some soup. So now here comes Louis walking past the dining room and we were sitting right by the door, the entrance. He says, "hey man, what you guys doing?" We said we've got to have something. He went "yeah I'm going to have some too." Next thing you know the whole band was sitting at our table. And she came, she was fuming. She was ranting and screaming, and Louis told her all kinds of words. I mean we've got to eat something, we're starving man, we're hungry, we'll do your concerts. Well you know how they are. Concert says 8:30, we've got to start at 8:30. It was crazy. So we all ate and we said get lost. And next thing you know a guy says I'll have a steak or give me a sandwich, and Louis says bring me some of this. So he says that's it man, get lost, get out. She was crazy man. But I'll tell you I don't know how Louis did it. You know how he did it? He loved it. Well of course his biggest thrill was being in front of people because he would always say those people came to see me, I'm going to do the best that I can do, which is very admirable, right?

MR: Did you ever have any problems with the fact that it was an integrated band racially?

MN: I'm sure there was, but I'm trying to think of what it was. In fact you know Ken Burns is doing a thing, right? And they came to my house two or three years ago and they came in with a crew of ten people. My basement is about as big as their — they had things all over the place. And they interviewed me and I told this story about we were in Texas and we were playing in a place called the Seven something, and we had taken a break and I went outside to get some fresh air, it was very hot in the room even though it was air conditioning, you know it gets hot. So I went outside and while I was sitting like this getting some sun, it got dark and I opened my eyes and I saw about four big Texas guys with the big necks like this, and they said, "Hey man." I said, "Yeah?" "How come you play with a nigger band?" I said, "What?" They said, "You heard me." I said, "What the hell are you talking about, man?" I said, "You know who that is? That's Louis Armstrong." "So what?" I said, "what do you mean, so what? Didn't you pay to come in to see him?" The guy says, "yeah." I said, "how much did you pay?" I forget, ten dollars?

I said, “I’m getting paid to work with him, you’re a bigger jerk than I am, aren’t you?” And just as I said that, Cozy was coming out to call me or something, and he heard me say that. He says, “Marty, telephone.” So he came to grab me and he pulled me in. He says, “are you crazy?” I said, “what?” He says, “didn’t you see the size of those guys?” I said, “yeah but did you hear what they said, I mean, come on, Cozy.” And the only other thing I saw was a couple of incidences. One was we were down south some place, well three or four. Now I had never worked with a mixed band before, so it was white bands. And in fact when I joined Louis it was three and three. Three white guys, three black guys, and a girl. And we were doing a one-nighter someplace, I forget, Texas or someplace down south. And I had never played the south before, strangely enough, with all the bands I’d been with. Now here I am with a mixed band and we were down south right? So we walked into a, it was about 7:00 in the morning and we stopped for breakfast at a restaurant. And we walked in and there was two or three guys behind the counter and they disappeared into the kitchen. So we sat down and Frenchie was the manager, he says, “all right guys let’s leave.” I said, “wait a minute, we just came in.” I was so naive, I didn’t know. He said, “let’s leave.” I said, “where we going? We didn’t eat.” He says, “Marty, let’s leave.” I said to somebody, “what the hell happened?” No, come on, Marty, did you see the guys disappear? I said oh yeah, the guys behind the counter, when we walked in they walked — so that was my first inkling what was happening. Then we stopped at a place, a gas station, it had rest rooms. And we went to the rest rooms and it said “Blacks” and “Whites.” And there was like a water fountain. So I went to get some water, and Velma came and I said, “Velma, the water is so cold, it’s delicious.” She said, “you know I can’t drink that.” I said, “get outta here. You come over here.” Velma was about 300 pounds and I was this skinny when I joined him. And I said, “go ahead, I’ll cover you.” She said, “get outta here, you jerk.” I said, “don’t worry Velma, I’ve got you covered.” And let me see there was another place. Oh I know one, we were playing in Austin Texas at a ballroom. And this is one thing that really surprised me because we had a guy that used to sell the programs in front of the theater when we were doing concerts. You know, the big programs that they sell with all the pictures and everything. So we’re going by bus and the bus breaks down about 20 or 30 miles outside of town. Okay? So the bus broke down so the guy calls for another bus because he couldn’t fix it, so we’re

waiting and now it's like 5 or 6:00 and the guys were getting hungry. So the manager was the white guy, Frenchie — excuse me, the ginger ale, it's human, it's real — so we said you know we just passed a diner about a hundred feet back there. So the guy that sold the programs, Frenchie and myself, we went there to get some food. We sat at the counter, we ate, and then we took out five or six, I don't know, for the rest of the guys. I took orders, like when you work in an office in New York, whoever wants coffee, who has a cheeseburger. So we took out some blue plate specials. And we walked back to the bus and the guys ate in the bus see? Now the other bus comes, picks us up there, change buses, we get in the other bus and we get to this ballroom, so the bus pulls up in front of the ballroom, so we go in the front entrance, and the bandstand is way at the other end of the dance floor. So we walked in and walked and naturally there was like no music or anything so everybody's sitting down at the tables. The dance floor is empty. We walked right across the dance floor, and the whole room got up, standing applause, because Louis is walking. And I said, "I can't believe this. It's weird. I can't believe this is happening here." You know these are the things that the first time I ever witnessed something like that in my lifetime. Because like I say prior to that I had always been with white bands and I never experienced anything like that. And well the funny thing happened once, we were in Florida and we were living in Miami and we had to do a one-nighter in West Palm Beach or something like that, not too far away. So I had a friend of mine who had a band down there and I had dinner with he and his wife and some friends of theirs. So his wife says, to me, "you know you're doing a concert tomorrow night at West Palm Beach, can we come with you?" And I said, "gee I don't know I'll have to ask my manager, you know I don't know what kind of situation it is." So I called Frenchie. I said, "Frenchie, I've got some friends they would like to come to the concert." He says, "how many people?" I said, "how many of you want to go?" So it was just his wife and her girlfriend said, we'd like to go with you. Okay, in fact she said, "we'll drive you down there because we know exactly where the place is." It was called something palace, but you should have seen the place, it was unbelievable. It was weird man. So anyway they drove me down there, and when we got in the place it was like a funky, like a social club, you know, where they have dances with the teenage stuff. It was a run down, broken down kind of place, and I looked for the bandstand and it was across the room and it was about

nine feet in the air. Like there was a balcony, a bandstand about eight or nine feet up, with a railing. I don't even know if it had a railing, with an upright piano that was on a slant. Because the floor slanted this way toward the thing. So I went up on the bandstand and Bob says to me, "you'd better get those two girls and bring them up here, because it could get rough." It could get rough. I says okay. They were both blondes too. I said, "hey girls, up here" so they come up and they sat on the bandstand all night with us.

MR: Well you've got an education then.

MN: Yeah, that was it you know. That's when I learned what was happening.

MR: Right. Did you want to show us a few items from your book?

MN: Any other bands you want to talk, or are we running out of time?

MR: Well, you did the Metropole.

MN: Oh boy that was great, I loved it. Guys would say to me, "why are you working that dump?" I said, "what do you mean, dump?" You know what I did at the Metropole? Well of course I worked with my own groups, I worked with other people, but I was there for about ten years, different people. And for approximately two and a half years I worked with Charlie Shavers, Coleman Hawkins, Mickey Sheen, and the bass players fluctuated, either Arvell Shaw or Benny Moten, different bass players. But with Charlie Shavers and Coleman Hawkins. And when Coleman took off, Roy Eldridge would play, and one night Charlie took off and he sent in Dizzy Gillespie. You know it was fantastic, man I loved it, it was just great. And it was just magnificent. Not only that, at that particular time all the country clubs around the New York metropolitan area would have like some Saturday night they would say why don't we have a Dixieland theme, who can we get? Who is at the Metropole? I got called all the time. Because I would work, like for instance there was a guy, Tony Cabot was a society bandleader. First he worked with Meyer Davis, and then he split and he got his own office, and he used to use me all the time. I worked with Tony for 30 years. But anyway he would call me, and I would work with his band on the date, to do [scats] I would play the jobs because I knew all those things see? Now a lot of the jazz guys don't. They know their jazz tunes and that's it. So they'd get Marty, because now and then they would say okay but we want you to bring a couple of guys, because during the night we're going to bring you out and let you play some Dixieland things. So I brought like Ruby Braff and Bud Freeman and people like that. So Tony

during the night would say "Now we're going to have — Marty's going to bring some guys out" and we would get on the floor and do a little bit. People went crazy. So now another country club says hey why don't we have a New Orleans type of — get that Marty. I did loads of those things. Not only that, I did about ten or twelve weeks on Art Ford's Channel 13 show, which was coming from Newark, and the only reason they called was because we were at the Metropole, they got most of their guys from the Metropole. Now Art Ford, the kind of music he liked was like Zutty Singleton, George Wettling, what they called "moldy fig" kind of music. Do you know what that is? You know, traditional jazz, the old. Zutty with the [scats] and all that kind of stuff. And now this girl that was hiring the musicians for the thing, she didn't know this much about who to hire. She didn't know any musicians at all. So when she met me, she would talk to me and say who should I get? I said well man there's so many guys around, come on. So I would give her a list of names and it went along pretty good until one time when he had already hired Buster Bailey on clarinet and I had recommended guys like Sammy Most, Tony Scott, Gerry Mulligan, Morgana King, these are like a different era, these are not like old fashioned Dixieland. So now we're doing a show and there's Buster Bailey and Sammy Most. Do you know Sammy Most? Now Sammy's a fantastic player, but he doesn't play like Buster Bailey and vice versa. So what happened was on the show, after the show, he went to the girl and he says, "who the hell hired this guy?" No he said, "why did you hire this kid on clarinet?" She said, "Well Marty said—" he said, "Marty said? Who's running this show, Marty or me?" That was the last time I played on it. So that was it. I said thanks a lot. But anyway she used to call my house to get information about who to hire, and my kids used to say, "Dad it's her again." They knew she was going to be on for three hours. All right now listen Red Allen plays well with Buster Bailey and J.C. Higginbotham, Charlie Shavers plays well with anybody. And tell her who plays well with who. Did you ever see it—

MR: Please write it down so that you don't have to keep calling back again and again, too, right?

MN: Who's that?

MR: This woman. You know I've had people do that over and over.

MN: Well she didn't know. She was well intentioned, she was a nice lady, I liked her, but I used to go, "don't you know — didn't you ever hear of Gerry Mulligan?" Anyway, so now who else did I say after that, the Metropole?

MR: You had a quartet with your brother?

MN: Oh yea, the Napoleon Brothers. That was great because we used to go to my mother's house and we'd fool around at the piano, and my sister used to say, "why don't you guys get a thing." So we seriously thought about it. We had the first rehearsal at my mother's house and man we worked well together. Because we're both piano players, we're brothers, but we never played together. So we played some things together, it sounded pretty good. So we said let's get a group, and we started rehearsing and rehearsing. Meanwhile I had played the Sands Hotel with Louis' band. And the manager was Jack Entrada, who used to run the Copacabana in New York. And Jack liked me. I hate to say it but every time I did a piano solo, I'd get a fantastic reaction see. So he used to come to me, put his arm around me, walk across the casino, he was a big guy, 6'3", he put his arm around me he'd say "Marty, if you ever get a group, call me, I want you to call me, you're welcome here anytime." In fact I think one of his letters is in here. And he said anytime. So when Teddy and I started to rehearse, I went to Joe Glaser and he said, "well it's hard to book two pianos, there are not too many jazz clubs which are going to get pianos" which is true. In fact we went into the Embers and we had, no was it the Embers? and we had a grand piano and an upright because it was hard to get two grands in a little jazz club. So Glaser kind of like dropped it, and I said well look, I've got a friend of mine named George Drake, he works with Bill Burham's office. So I called and he says, "we'll come and hear you." So he came to hear us rehearse at Nola Studios. He says, "man you guys are great." We got a bass and a drum, Georgie Shaw and Herbie Wasson. And the group sounded fantastic. So we'd been rehearsing for some time too. And I suggested I said look Jack Entrada has always said to me if you ever get a group, I'm going to call Jack. So they called Jack. He said, "send him out." Just like that. He didn't want to hear the group. He said, "send him out." So they booked four weeks, with four two week options. Right? And we went out there and they loved us there, but we were playing in the lounge, and in those days the lounge was open. See nowadays I think the lounges are closed, and you have to go specifically into the room to catch the show. So you either

play the big room or the lounge. And we were playing in the lounge and it was open. So now we're playing on the stand and the bar was long, we were playing over here and the bar went long that way see? So actually we were playing out towards the audience this way and the people are gambling there. So what happened was, we were swinging so hard, that the people started turning around looking at the group and keeping time with their chips, and the dealers were getting bugged. They'd say hey man, you guys playing or what are you doing? So the pit boss would walk over to us one day and said, "hey guys, you want to keep it down please?" These guys were keeping time with the chips. So we said okay, so now we toned it down. Now we're playing for the people in the bar. But the bar was narrow and long. So the manager comes over to us and says, "Hey, the people out there say they can't hear you on the other end of the bar." We said well the pit boss said — he said, "The pit boss said?" You're working in the lounge, don't listen to the pit boss, you listen to me, I'm the manager. So okay. So here comes the pit boss. "Hey you guys." We said, "What? Speak to the manager?" He says, "Never mind the manager, we're trying to make some money here." It went that was for four weeks. And when we said, it's never going to work, we'll never pick up any options, we're fighting with these guys. They're going to throw us out pretty soon because they're going to say hey, get lost. So after four weeks we split. Now we were the headliners. Napoleon Brothers, and in fact Barbara Carroll, she was on the bill, one of the things. And then we did three weeks like that and the fourth week we were working midnight to six AM. And my brother Andy was playing with a trio at another hotel, the Flamingo or someplace, the Sahara. And he was working from six to midnight. He'd finish work and he'd come over to see us. So now on the last week we said we're going to try to leave here on closing night and get a good start, we had to go to Columbus, Ohio to play a gig there. So we said, "switch our schedule" so instead of midnight to six AM, they put us on from 6 PM to midnight. And you know what that did to us? It did this to our stomachs. It twisted us completely around, because we were going to be at 8:00 in the morning, getting up at 6, 5 at night, having breakfast and then going to work. It was crazy. Now all of a sudden we're getting through at midnight, and started getting stomach pains. It was just crazy. So what happened was they gave our spot, that midnight to six, to Louis Jordan's group. So one night he says to us, "Where are you guys going from here?" We said, "We're going

to Columbus we're leaving tomorrow night after the gig." He says, "You're leaving after the gig? You're going to drive" We says, "Yeah." He says, "Let me give you a little clue. Don't drive more than 200 miles, I don't care how cold it is, without getting out the car and running around the car ten times." We said, "What?" "Trust me." I think he saved our lives. Because we did it, we listened to him. Because we had two cars, we were caravan style. And we went a couple of hundred miles, we stopped, got out of the car, [breathes] ready. So that's what we did. So Louis Jordan saved our lives. And then we went to Columbus, Ohio, and we played there for about four weeks and it was freezing. Man we had snow and sleet and ice. And Teddy and I had a suite of rooms there and we put the T.V. on just while we were getting dressed to go to work, and the guy would say, if you don't have business out there, don't go out tonight, stay home. This guy was ruining our business — shut up. We'd go to work the place would be packed. Packed. We packed the room every night. They loved it. It was great. Because we had two grand pianos, and we used to play and then we would sing like [sings] "Straighten Up and Fly Right." And then we'd play fours, like I'd play then he'd play then we'd do fours. Then we would scat fours across the piano, and the bass and drum are playing [scats]. Man I'll tell you I loved it. I'm so disappointed that we didn't continue on and do better with that group, because after that we went to Chicago and it was a bad, bad, bad booking, because they booked us in there Easter week and we had absolutely no business at all in the place, no business. So that was like our demise. From there on it was downhill all the way. And then after that — that was '55, in '66 I went back with Louis. And the funny thing is by that time, when I was with Louis when my kids were little, I used to call my wife twice a week. Every Thursday night and every Sunday morning. Thursday night I talked to my wife and Sunday morning because I could talk to the kids. And they used to cry and cry, they didn't want to talk to me, and finally my daughter didn't want to talk. I said why is she crying? She says everybody has a daddy but me. Oh man it broke my heart. And then Thursday night I talked to her, I said, "Daddy's going to make some money, I want to buy you some—" I don't want —" Okay I finally convinced her that everything was okay, I said, "put your brother on." She said, "he doesn't want to talk to you." He was two years old. "He don't want to talk to you either, he's crying." So I said that's it. I went to the manager, I called him, I said, "Frenchie, I'm giving my notice." I quit the band

see? So now in '66, Glaser calls me again because — what happened? Oh he said, "we're going into Jones Beach." That's what made me go back with the band. They were going to Jones Beach in New York for the summer. Because Guy Lombardo used to put a show out there every year for the whole summer, So that convinced me to say okay. And I did, I went back in '66. And it's too long a story. But what else have you got to do?

MR: Well we're going to have to do Part Two sometime.

MN: Oh yeah? All right.

MR: Next time I come back. Because I don't want you to miss your ride here.

MN: Is it almost 6?

MR: It's almost 20 of.

MN: Well then let's go. Okay.

MR: Well hold on for a second.

MN: Oh you want to look at them things.

MR: Very quickly, what's your take on the state of jazz today?

MN: Jazz is alive I love it. There's nothing wrong with jazz, it's just we're not getting enough exposure to the people. Because not enough radio stations play it, and like you get KCR and BGO, they're playing some far out jazz that a lot of people don't really like to listen to. So that's my personal feeling. Because sometimes I listen to those stations and I don't really like what I hear. Because I'm from the old jazz, you know, like Bunny Berigan, guys like this. And I love jazz, but when I listen to some of those things, you know when they do these free for all things, it just turns me off, I just don't like it. So I feel if I don't like it and I'm a musician, can you imagine the average lay person who listens and says what the hell is that?

MR: Yeah, what are they doing?

MN: Yeah, what is that? So I feel sad because you know how I know there's a market for it? I went to Europe about five years in a row with Peanuts Hucko. We were doing a tribute to Louis Armstrong. We had Peanuts, Trummy Young, Billy Butterfield, Jack Lesberg and Gus Johnson. When I tell you we went to Portugal for one night, and we played opposite a kid who was a local hero, who had a hit record, he was about 23 years old, and he was fantastic. He had all kinds of amplifiers. Three guys they sounded like a whole orchestra. It was great. And he had a hit record and he was from that town, and they loved him. And

we had to follow him. So now he breaks it up, I mean completely. Now to introduce us and we come out, and we get [sparse applause]. We started to play "Back Home Again Indiana," well you never heard anything like that in your whole life. Clomping, Stamping, Cheering, Whistling, "hey you guys are great man." They went crazy. We tore it up. We had to do four encores, they wouldn't let us off the stage. I said man this is fantastic. These six old guys come on here and they say what's going on. I was with the world's greatest band too, the world's greatest. Joe Muranyi. Everybody in the band was great. People loved it. They were swinging. I mean when the band is swinging it gets to the people, I don't care what you say.

MR: Terrific.

MN: Can we tell that guy to hold on?

MR: Yeah, well thanks for your time. It's been fantastic.

MN: Did you want to look at anything at all?

MR: Sure.

MN: Let me see what we've got here, I don't know. Stop me when you see something you like. This is my father playing piano, my uncle Phil playing trumpet, my uncle Georgie playing violin, my first house, my first group, my first big band. My father used to do things like that. This is my father, my uncle, my mother.

MR: Is this you?

MN: That's what everybody says, is that you? That's why I had to quit. When I was going to Europe with Peanuts Hucko, we had the program notes, and after the concert people would come in the office into the dressing room and they would open up the program to your picture — oh there's Trummy Young — and when they came to me they were looking to the picture. Oh now here we are, is that you? I said that's it, I've got to get some new pictures. That's my wife when I met her. This is Bob Astor, Shelly Manne, Chico Marx. There's Chico with my wife and I when we were kids. This is Mel Torme.

MR: Well let me get some shots of these why don't we wrap up. And we'll see if we can go with that. That's terrific. Thanks.

MN: Thank you, Monk, you're beautiful. Thank you very much, it's very comforting. You made me talk more than I should have.

MR: Well no way, appreciate it.

MN: Well because you know how it is, like I remember watching the Johnny Carson show when somebody on the show would say "yeah well you're making a new movie, right?" And the guy would say, "yeah." Ooh God, okay, next case. So you need it.

MR: Absolutely.

MN: Thank you.